

Stanley

Suddenly they were everywhere. Tall stainless steel tumblers bearing the name Stanley in a rainbow of muted colors were in the hands of college students and women on the go, peeking out the sides of high school students' backpacks and gym bags. All across the country, Stanley was shining where Hydro Flasks¹ had once reigned supreme. Stanley was a brand long associated with durable, vacuum-sealed thermoses and containers for workers traveling to various jobsites and outdoor enthusiasts.

Could this be the same Stanley? How had the century-old brand managed to find such extraordinary popularity with a new audience virtually overnight, going from a relatively niche brand to one of the most recognizable in American culture? And how did PMI Worldwide, Stanley's parent company, manage to adjust its supply chain and channel strategy to meet such an explosive growth in demand?

Background



Figure 1. The classic Stanley thermos

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Stanley is a U.S. brand with deep roots in America's industrial past. In 1913, William Stanley invented the all-steel, double-wall vacuum thermos and put his name on it (Figure 1). Throughout the 20th century, Stanley developed a brand synonymous with quality and durability in outdoor settings, primarily for its core demographic: workers who needed a durable, nonbreakable way to carry coffee or other hot beverages to jobsites and outdoor adventurers engaged in camping, hiking, and other vigorous pursuits.

By the mid-2010s, however, reusable water bottles were becoming a popular cultural phenomenon, and PMI was paying attention. Companies like CamelBak and Coleman moved from the outdoor enthusiast market into the mainstream. Later, Hydro Flask found enormous success with a broad market base of Millennial and Gen Z consumers.

In 2016, Stanley introduced the Quencher (Figure 2), a vacuum-insulated tumbler-style cup initially designed to cater to its core demographic, retaining the classic thermos's sturdiness and reliability. The Quencher was offered in sizes ranging from 14 to 40 ounces; features included a removable straw, vacuum insulation to hold the contents at a desired temperature (hot or cold) for extended periods, a base designed to fit a vehicle cupholder, and

¹ Hydro Flask is a reusable, insulated water bottle that soared in popularity in the 2010s.

multiple color options, including seasonal offerings.



Figure 2. The Stanley quencher
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A Changing Target Market

Influencer marketing campaigns on social media, particularly TikTok, contributed to the Quencher's early success, and sales soared in 2019. The Quencher became difficult to find, though, and some fans feared it would be discontinued. That's when Ashlee LeSeur, Taylor Cannon, and Lindley Hutchinson—founders of the online marketplace and product review site The Buy Guide—took action. They spoke to Stanley directly, advocating for expanded Quencher production and a broader marketing strategy aimed at women.

"We had heard that Stanley was discontinuing the 40-oz Quencher," Hutchinson recalled. "So we were telling all our followers, 'Hurry, get your hands on any cup that you can find. We've heard that this is going away. Please tell Stanley that you don't want it to go away, that you love the cup so much'" (Jansen 2023).

Matt Navarro, senior vice president of global commerce at Stanley, denied that there were ever plans to discontinue its Quencher production but acknowledged the tumbler "wasn't prioritized at the time" (Jansen 2023). Intrigued by The Buy Guide's interest, Stanley executives invited the leaders to meet in 2019 to discuss strategy. Instead of offering The Buy Guide a commission to promote the Quencher—called an affiliate strategy in influencer marketing—Stanley executives suggested that The Buy Guide place a wholesale order for a minimum of 10,000 tumblers and sell the Quenchers themselves (Jansen 2023). The BuyGuide did not specify the wholesale price they paid for the tumblers.²

"It was a huge risk," Cannon said. The Buy Guide team had to create a website, acquire a warehouse, and establish a delivery channel. "We ordered those cups and were like, 'we don't know if we're going to sell out of these tomorrow, or if we're going to be trying to get rid of cups for the rest of our lives.'" (Jansen 2023)

The cups were gone in five days. According to Cannon, Stanley executives were shocked: "It blew their minds" (Jansen 2023).

Stanley's executives—including new President Terence Reilly, who joined the Stanley team in 2020 and had previously held an executive leadership role with the popular shoe brand

² In 2024, Stanley offered Quenchers in bulk at a wholesale price of \$30, compared to a retail price of approximately \$45.

CROCS—saw the wisdom in The Buy Guide’s strategy and decided to start targeting women. Stanley modified the Quencher’s appearance, adding more colors, patterns, and prints, and launched a marketing campaign directed at women. They teamed up with celebrities like country music star Lainey Wilson and actor Laura Prepon, who both featured Stanley on their social media sites, and the company shared user-generated content (videos and pictures of customers with their Stanley Quenchers) on Stanley’s social media (Keyhole 2024).

As a result of the new targeting and promotion strategies, Stanley experienced explosive growth in demand for Quenchers. In 2020, sales were \$70 million; by 2023, sales were \$750 million—a more than 1000% increase. (Vega and Shamo 2023)

Impact on Supply Chain and Channel Strategy

Stanley faced a unique challenge. For many decades, its best-selling product was a thermos produced in a single deep-green color and sold through relatively niche retail channels, such as sporting and outdoor-oriented stores. But demand dictated that Stanley make the Quencher available in more places, like Target and Starbucks.

Stanley partnered with Target to develop the exclusive Hearth & Hand collection. They partnered with Starbucks to develop limited edition colors and patterns for the seasons, including a red Quencher that was being resold on eBay (for hundreds of dollars) within hours of its release. These channel strategies resulted in even greater demand. Stanley was no longer a utilitarian product for trades workers—the new female customer base wanted Stanleys for multiple purposes and occasions. The product was becoming a collector’s item as well as a statement piece: one size and color for morning coffee, another for work-day water consumption, and yet another for evening workouts.

These channel partners helped Stanley make a wider variety of products available to more consumers. However, the explosive growth in demand put pressure on Stanley’s supply chain, including its manufacturing operations in China and Brazil as well as the suppliers that provided the steel, aluminum, plastic, paint, and packaging. Stanley also needed manufacturing capabilities that could adjust to different sizes, paint colors, and patterns quickly, depending on demand for the various product options and the new designs being developed through retail partners. Customers complained about the shortages, but even that seemed to only feed demand.

The expansion of production also increased the complexity of operations and inventory management due to the additional number of product variations. Advanced inventory management systems were essential for accurate demand forecasting and reducing excess stock. In 2024, Stanley contracted with a new supply-chain management provider, with plans to use artificial intelligence to facilitate future growth.

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